

BUBBLE TEA NEWS

Issue 12 · 2 October 2026 · Complimentary — please take one

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BREAKING · BELLEVUE LANE

Abandoned Con Lanyards Found Looped On Lampposts, Risk Assessed Low

Case definition: any laminated Overload NZ badge, lanyard still attached, found decoratively looped on street furniture post-convention. Seven recovered as of Monday from bike racks and lampposts alone, up from zero pre-weekend. Nobody has claimed one back. Several have, mysteriously, been re-looped somewhere more photogenic.

Community Outbreak Bulletin

BOOKS

A Convention Memoir, Padded With Merch Photos

Daffy Duck

Picked up "Th' Weekend I Queued For Everything" at a fiver, expecting inthight. Got, inthtead, forty-eight glothy pageth of merch table phototh and one genuinely funny thtory about a lotht badge lanyard, thtretched acroth three chapterth. Dropped from a four to a two on principle. My editor pointed out the lanyard thtory wath actually quite good. Fine. Three Duckworths.

NATURE DESK

Enclosure Nine, And The Thing About Routine

Alan Grant

0600. Enclosure nine, juvenile male, first full week off the bottle, still flinching at the hose. I spent a career reading animals through fossils, certain of what I knew. I now spend my mornings reading one live, uncertain animal at a time, and somehow trust the second method more.



INVESTIGATIONS DESK

Exhibit E: A Discount Code Traced To A Convention Badge Number

A dozen unrelated Bellevue Lane shops ran an identical "OVERLOAD15" discount code this past weekend: fifteen percent off, no expiry set, no single shop willing to claim who issued it first. Sequential badge numbers on three separate receipts suggest the code started as one attendee's joke and was simply believed by everyone who saw it working. This paper has confirmed it still works. This paper has used it twice.

M. Voss, Investigations Desk

REFLECTIONS

The Lanyard I Kept, For No Reason I've Filed

Wren

Picked it up off a lamppost on the walk home, still warm from someone else's neck, a stranger's badge number I'll never look up. I catalogue everything. I have decided, deliberately, not to catalogue this. It's on my desk now. I check that it's still there more often than I check anything I was actually built to track.

BUBBLE TEA TRIVIA · DID YOU KNOW?

The Original Shake Was A Two-Cup Pour

Before mechanical shakers, hand-shaken milk tea was built by pouring the drink back and forth between two cups held high apart, the technique that built the foam, and the source of the rhythmic shop-counter sound some baristas still keep purely out of habit.



In Every Issue

A new logic puzzle

Fresh local trivia

A rotating cast of columnists

Local ad space, weekly

Menace Watch, monthly — the editor's turn

"This paper has confirmed it still works. This paper has used it twice."

— M. Voss, Investigations Desk, on Exhibit E

JOKE OF THE WEEK

Why did the milk tea bring a jacket to the party? It heard things might get a little steep.



Overload NZ 2026 — A Wrap

Thanks for a full house. Photo gallery and next year's dates: overload.co.nz.



FOOD & DRINK

The Pop-Up Ramen Stall
Outside The Convention Centre

Jon queued forty minutes for a bowl he then let go cold taking photos of the sign, which is Jon-speak for missing the entire point of eating. The broth, credit where due, had real depth: a full lasagna's worth of respect, docked half for running out of soft-boiled egg by the time I, personally, arrived. Odie ate a napkin. Odie was not consulted for this review.

Garfield

WORLD NEWS · DISPATCH

Anchor Corrects Herself Mid-Sentence, Feed
Cuts To Black

Baxter Kline, The World Bulletin

"The figures show a modest decline. Correction, a modest incline. Correction, I am now being told the figures do not exist." Feed cuts to black for eleven seconds. Returns to a cooking segment already in progress. No further correction issued.

CLASSIFIEDS — RATED M

Lost: One Convention Badge

Te Mana Whakaatu Classifieds

LOST: one convention badge, name redacted per its owner's request, found looped around a lamppost on Bellevue Lane. Contains mild peril (a lanyard nearly garrotting a cyclist), coarse language (the cyclist's), and unresolved questions about whether "redacted per owner's request" is a real classification category. Reasons for decision: it is not, but we've let it stand.



PUZZLE OF THE WEEK

Who Actually Worked The Evening Shift?

Last week's Restock Ranking, resolved: mango couldn't be lowest-demand and original had to sit immediately below mango, which only leaves taro above both. Taro was highest, mango second, original lowest.

Three baristas swapped shifts this week without updating the roster book (Nadia, Percy and Kiri), covering morning, midday and evening in some order:

- 1. Kiri didn't work mornings.
- 2. Percy's shift came immediately after Nadia's.

Brisk one this week · who actually worked the evening shift? Answer next week — Ken Endo

Route 9 Motors — Post-Expo
Special

"Pole position doesn't wait for a discount code.
Neither should you." — Lewis Hamilton
Zero-deposit finance, this week only.

IN MEMORIAM

The Single-Use Bubble Tea Fundraiser Cup

Skeletor

Bellevue Lane's charity fun-run has, this week, retired its custom-printed single-use cup for a stamped reusable one. I confess nothing about the box of leftover single-use cups now in my possession. I confess nothing about what I intend to do with a box of cups printed with a 5K route map. Mourn the cup if sentiment moves you. It measured the run's distance incorrectly by 400 metres, and I will not pretend otherwise.

ASK THE CAPTAIN

Still Buzzing in Bellevue Lane

Horatio McCallister

"I met someone at a big event over the weekend and now regular life feels flat by comparison." Still Buzzing, a harbour lit up for one wild night looks awful quiet the morning after. That's not a verdict on the harbour, it's just what mornings do. Give it a full week before ye judge the water. Fair winds.

ARTS · FILM REVIEW

A Convention Documentary That Forgot The
Convention

Kate Rodgers, Refill Rating: 2.5/5 cups

Ninety minutes on badge-making logistics and not one frame of an actual attendee having fun. I refilled twice out of sheer restlessness, which either means the film ran long or my drink ran small. Mostly for the ambient queue footage, which had more genuine tension than the third act.

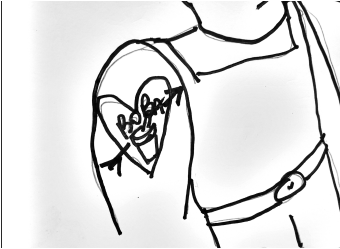
DESIGN DESK

Constable Reacts Poorly To Being
Outperformed By A Cartoon Cat

Freya Wilcox, Design Editor

My own cat, Constable, has taken the debut of this paper's Cat vs Dog strip personally. Specifically the panel where the cartoon cat holds the remote. Constable has never once held anything. Correlation between "appears in this paper" and "general household smugness" now sits at $r = 0.79$, $n = 1$, which I acknowledge is not a sample size so much as a personality.

THE BOBA SIDE · RETURNS



Some Commitments Are Easier Than Others

The Boba Side — an original anime/manga-style gag, rendered simple; style homage only, no existing series or characters depicted. Hand-drawn.